

5.4 AREAS OF STUDY

The Areas of Study define the subject content through the study of which candidates develop their aural perception, musical knowledge and understanding of:

- the use of musical elements, devices, tonalities and structures;
- the use of resources, conventions, processes and relevant notations including staff notation;
- the contextual influences that affect the way music is created, performed and heard (for example, the effect of different intentions, uses, venues, occasions, available resources and the cultural environment).

The content of each Area of Study is set out under four headings:

The **Starting Point** defines the broad area of knowledge which provides the background for the in-depth studies defined in the core. The Starting Points are designed to enable teachers to draw on experiences and understanding developed in Key Stage 3 and to lead into more detailed study.

The **Core** defines the in-depth understanding that is central to the Area of Study. It provides the particular focus for more detailed learning.

Links indicate opportunities for teachers to draw together materials from different Areas of Study in ways which will lead to more integrated understanding.

Language for Learning lists the terminology which candidates should encounter in the Area of Study. This will be drawn on in the Listening Paper. A summary list of all the Language for Learning is provided in Appendix A for ease of reference.

5.4.1 Area of Study 1 - Exploiting the Resource

Starting Point

The way the candidate's chosen instrument (or voice) produces and exploits its sound:

- its range/compass;
- its characteristic timbre/colour;
- its technical strengths and limitations;
- idiomatic performing techniques;
- enhancement using ICT (where appropriate);
- its place in its 'family' (e.g. trumpet in relation to cornet, or as the highest instrument in an orchestral brass group, bass guitar in relation to other electric guitars and acoustic guitar).

Core

Candidates should develop an understanding of how their instrument (or voice) is used in a selected genre, through the study of three pieces, at least one of which must be performed by the candidate. This study should enable candidates to recognise similarities and differences in the way in which their instrument is exploited in relation to:

- the contextual background of the pieces studied;

- the use of different instrument-specific techniques;
- either: the roles of performers in a relevant ensemble and the contribution of the selected instrument
or: ways in which the instrument may be self-sufficient as an unaccompanied soloist;
- ways in which music is created/recreated and the contributions of different composers, conductors/leaders or performers;
- the way the music is notated and the different ways notations are interpreted by performers (e.g. Baroque ornamentation, rhythmic flexibility in jazz idioms, different ways of performing from chord symbols on keyboards);
- changing social expectations and the influence (where appropriate) of new technology.

It is important that the genre be identified in a way that offers scope for suitable depth of study e.g. solo music for the instrument across a range of historical periods, a specific type of pop, music for keyboards, songs from musicals, or solo studies which explore aspects of technique. Three pieces should be selected which will enable comparisons to be drawn and which will support understanding of similarities and differences in pieces within the genre.

Links

Area of Study 2: candidates whose instrument usually fulfils a predominantly melodic role should be encouraged to examine the melodic nature of the selected pieces to support their understanding of *Techniques of Melodic Composition*. In a similar way, performers on chordal or percussive instruments (or predominantly bass instruments such as tuba) might focus on the ways in which their instrument provides a harmonic or rhythmic support to melodies. In the Terminal Task (4.3.1) candidates will have the option either to communicate their melodic response to a given stimulus by performing it on their own instrument (or using ICT) or to submit it in written form.

Areas of Study 3 and 4: candidates will have the opportunity to compare how instruments other than their own are exploited by composers and performers in their study of *Dance Music* and *Traditions and Innovation*. They will also be able to draw on their understanding of their own instrument in their composition of a piece in one of the styles defined by these two areas.

Language for Learning

Candidates should be taught to understand, recognise aurally, and correctly use the following terminology which describes features which arise specifically within the content of this Area of Study:

Range, compass, timbre, articulation and words associated with techniques specific to the instrument (e.g. arco, double-tonguing, rim shot, fill).

The names of the composers of the music studied should also be known.